

THE GARGANO — THE SPUR OF ITALY

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CAP. 1 — INTRO: THE GARGANO IN WINTER

I know the Gargano in winter.

When you leave — at the end of August, in September — I stay. I lock the gates, drain the pools, put the chairs under the tarpaulins. And then the Gargano goes back to being itself.

My name is Vincenzo. Sixty-six years old, caretaker and maintenance man at a seafront residence for thirty years. In summer I manage two hundred people. In winter I manage the silence.

The Gargano in winter is a different thing. The forest goes dark and deep, the tramontana wind pushes three-metre waves onto the coast, the villages empty out. And what's left is the real structure of the place — the rock, the sea, the forest.

I'll tell you about the Gargano as I see it. Not the one on the tourist posters. The real one.

CAP. 2 — WHAT THE GARGANO IS: THE SPUR

Look at a map of Italy.

There's the boot — the toe, the heel, the leg. And then there's this piece of land jutting out into the Adriatic Sea like a spur, like a kick toward the east. That's the Gargano.

It's not Puglia in the usual sense. The Puglia people imagine is flat, sun-baked, olive trees and white stone. The Gargano is mountainous — it reaches twelve hundred metres above sea level, it has a beech and oak forest covering forty thousand hectares, it has coastal lagoons, white-rock inlets, sea caves.

It's a block of limestone that broke away from the Dolomites and drifted south millions of years ago. Geologically speaking, the Gargano has nothing to do with the rest of Puglia.

It's an intruder. And that's why it's so different.

National Park since 1991. A hundred and eighty thousand protected hectares. One of the last wild areas in southern Italy.

CAP. 3 — FORESTA UMBRA: THE FOREST YOU DON'T EXPECT

The first time a tourist enters the Foresta Umbra, they stop.

They don't expect it. They come to Puglia for the sea, for the heat, for the white beaches. And they find themselves in a beech forest that looks like it belongs in the Alps.

The Foresta Umbra is the green heart of the Gargano. Eleven thousand hectares of primary forest — meaning forest that has never been systematically logged, that has grown on its own for centuries. Beech trees with trunks two metres across. Turkey oaks thirty metres tall. Thousand-year-old yews.

The name comes from Latin — umbra, shadow. Even in midsummer, inside the forest it's twenty degrees. The sun doesn't reach the ground. The leaves filter everything.

I go in autumn. When the beeches turn red and orange and leaves fall on the path. You walk and hear nothing but the wind in the branches. It's one of the quietest places I know.

Deer, fallow deer, roe deer, wild boar all live here. At night I hear boar passing near the residence — they make a specific sound, a scraping of earth and undergrowth. After thirty years I recognise it straight away.

CAP. 4 — VIESTE: THE WHITE CITY ON THE SEA

Vieste is the easternmost city in mainland Puglia.

The old centre sits on a promontory of white rock that drops vertically into the sea. White houses stacked on top of each other, lanes so narrow two people squeeze past each other, staircases leading down to the water.

The Pizzomunno is the white rock standing in front of the main beach. A sixteen-metre monolith rising from the water. There's a legend — a young fisherman named Pizzomunno and his beloved Cristalda separated by sirens who dragged him to the bottom of the sea. The rock is him, turned to stone for eternity, waiting for her.

Vieste in summer is one of the most visited destinations in the South. Count two hundred and fifty thousand visitors in August. For a city of fourteen thousand inhabitants.

Vieste in winter has fourteen thousand inhabitants and total silence. The bars are open, the market is open, people live their lives. But the beaches are empty and the sea does what it likes.

I prefer Vieste in April. Still cool, few people, the sea already emerald green but without the crowds.

CAP. 5 — THE COAST: CAVES, INLETS AND SEA STACKS

The Gargano coast is the most beautiful thing here.

I have to say it plainly because people don't understand until they see it. It's not just any coastline. It's white limestone ending in the Adriatic with sea stacks, natural arches, marine caves, inlets you can only reach from the water.

The Grotta Smeralda, the Grotta delle Viole, the Grotta del Turco — caverns opening onto the sea where the water turns electric blue and aquamarine from the way light enters through the rock. You can only see them by boat. We call them grottos, the brochures call them natural wonders. They're saying the same thing.

The most beautiful beaches aren't reachable by car. Scalo di Portogreco, Cala Josefa, Baia delle Zagare — you either go by boat or walk rocky paths for twenty minutes. No beach clubs, no umbrella rental, no music. Just rock, water and silence.

I have a dinghy. When the residence is closed, sometimes I go out early in the morning and follow the coast alone. With a flat sea and low light, that coastline looks like the most beautiful place on earth.

CAP. 6 — MONTE SANT'ANGELO: THE SANCTUARY IN THE ROCK

Monte Sant'Angelo is not a tourist stop.

It's one of the oldest pilgrimage sites in Europe. Even if you're not a believer, even if religion doesn't interest you, go. Because what you feel in there doesn't have a simple explanation.

The sanctuary is dedicated to the Archangel Michael. According to tradition, Michael appeared in a cave on the Gargano in 490 AD. Not once — three times, in three different years. The third appearance was in 493, and from that moment the cave became a sacred place.

It's not a church built over a cave. It's a church built inside a cave. You descend eighty-six steps and arrive in a natural cavern where the rock is the ceiling, the walls, the floor. The altar is in the rock.

For fifteen hundred years, pilgrims from across Europe have made this journey — Lombards, Crusaders, Normans, Swabians. Charlemagne passed through here. Francis of Assisi passed through here — but stopped outside, considering himself unworthy to enter a place consecrated by the Archangel himself.

When you descend those steps, you feel the weight of fifteen hundred years of faith. I don't know how else to put it. It weighs.

CAP. 7 — PESCHICI AND THE VILLAGES: THE NORTHERN COAST

Peschici is the most beautiful village on the Gargano.

I'm saying that as someone who lives in Vieste — so you understand it takes something.

Peschici clings to a rocky spur on the edge of the northern promontory. White houses that look ready to fall into the sea, lanes with flowers on the balconies, a Norman castle on top. Three thousand inhabitants, fifty thousand in August.

Rodi Garganico is further west — surrounded by citrus groves, famous for its oranges and lemons. In January, when the whole Gargano is grey and bare, the groves of Rodi are heavy with orange fruit. It looks like something put there on purpose.

Ischitella, Vico del Gargano — inland villages where people live who never saw the need to leave. Narrow streets, baroque churches, old people sitting outside their doors. Life as it's always been, carrying on regardless of tourism.

CAP. 8 — THE TREMITI ISLANDS: THE PARADISE YOU HAVE TO EARN

The Tremiti Islands are twenty-two kilometres offshore.

You get there by ferry from Vieste, from Peschici, from Rodi, from Manfredonia. In summer there are constant crossings. In winter there are two crossings a week. The islands' winter population is just over three hundred.

San Domino is the largest island. It has a pine forest, the most beautiful sea caves in the Adriatic, water that in some spots changes colour three times within a hundred metres — green, turquoise, deep blue.

San Nicola is the island of history. A tenth-century Benedictine abbey, still standing, still inhabited by monks. The island is almost entirely occupied by the monastery and castle. No hotels, no restaurants. Just monks and ruins.

Something few people know: the Tremiti were a place of exile. First Bourbon exile in the 1800s — political prisoners sent there. Then Fascist exile in the 1930s — regime opponents sent there. Paradise and prison, in the same place.

CAP. 9 — THE FOOD: WHAT YOU EAT HERE

The fish.

I don't need to explain much. We're on a promontory jutting into the Adriatic — the fish is fresh, caught the night before, cooked simply.

The Gargano brodetto is the main dish. It's not the same as the brodetto from the Marche or Romagna — every coast has its own. Here it's made with tomato, garlic, chilli, and the catch of the day — scorpionfish, weever, gurnard, octopus. Eaten with toasted bread to soak up the sauce.

The oysters from Lesina. Lake Lesina is one of the Gargano's coastal lagoons — separated from the sea by a thin strip of land, brackish water, perfect temperatures for oyster farming. If you're in the area, you'll find them raw with lemon and there's nothing better.

The wine of the Gargano is Nero di Troia. Red, tannic, with an iron aftertaste that pairs perfectly with brodetto. It's not an elegant wine — it's a robust wine, for people who work hard and eat well.

CAP. 10 — THE TRADITIONS: WHAT REMAINS

Thirty years on the Gargano have taught me one thing.

Here, tradition is not folklore for tourists.

The transhumance is over — or nearly. For centuries, from autumn to spring, shepherds came down from the Apennines with their flocks along the tratturi — those grass roads a hundred metres wide that cross the Tavoliere plain and climb up to the Gargano. Millions of sheep every year. An entire economy built on this movement.

The tratturi still exist. They're state heritage. I drive along one sometimes and think about how many thousands of sheep walked that same ground.

The feast of San Michele is on 29 September. Monte Sant'Angelo fills with pilgrims from across Puglia and Basilicata. Not tourists — pilgrims. People who come on foot from far away, as they always did, and as they still do today.

It's one of the things that makes me think some places have a force of their own. That carry on by themselves, regardless of who lives there or passes through.

CAP. 11 — ADVICE: WHEN TO COME AND WHAT TO DO

June and September.

Not July, not August. Unless you enjoy queuing to park, waiting an hour at a restaurant, finding the beach packed to the water's edge.

In June the water is already warm, the beaches are half empty, prices are normal. In September the sea is at its warmest, the tourists have gone, restaurants cook with more care.

For the sea: hire a boat. Even for just one day. The Gargano coast seen from the water is completely different. The caves open up, the colours change, you reach places that don't exist on road maps.

For the forest: go early morning. Before ten, when the Visitor Centre car park is still empty. Take one of the marked paths and walk at least an hour into the woods. Don't stay at the edge of the road.

Monte Sant'Angelo — go early morning or late afternoon. When the tourist coaches aren't there. That sanctuary with few people is a completely different experience.

CAP. 12 — CLOSING: VINCENZO SAYS GOODBYE

Thirty years of opening and closing gates.

I've watched families come back every year — same apartments, same weeks. I know them by name. I've watched children grow up, become teenagers, then adults, then arrive with their own children.

People come back to the Gargano. I can't explain exactly why. It's something in the relationship between the forest and the sea — two things that normally don't sit this close together, and here they touch. From the woods to the sea in twenty minutes. From the sea to the woods in twenty minutes.

In winter, when I'm alone, I do my check every morning. I check the structures, check the gates, look at the sea. And I think that this place, with nobody in it, is still beautiful.

Maybe that's why I stay.

Welcome to the Gargano. Take it slowly. It's worth it.